with framed photographs of heroes of the Indian Air Force and famous patriotic quotes. One such photograph I fondly remember is of the 1971 war hero Flying Officer Nirmaljeet Singh Sekhon, PVC, and alongside it is written, ‘Who kept the faith and fought the fight; the glory theirs, the duty ours.’

‘Hurry up, everyone. Line up on the veranda for the Pilot Aptitude Battery Test [PABT]; it begins at quarter to nine,’ Deepa hurriedly announced as she ran from one barracks to another in her enthusiasm to discharge her duties right. She was a candidate appointed by Sqn Ldr Yadav to pass his orders to the rest of us. ‘Now that’s how you earn brownie points,’ Aditi, an Excel academy candidate, commented plainly as she looked at the rest of us.

‘Another test! They could have waited until tomorrow,’ someone said.

To be able to fly the big bad machines that dominate the skies, an Indian Air Force candidate must clear the PABT. Papaji had learnt about it from one of his air force friends. But even knowing about the test didn’t keep me from fretting. The test was designed to assess a candidate’s aptitude to be a pilot. It wasn’t just a single test but three types of tests, further subdivided into multiple tests. The Instruments Battery Test (INSB) would be a paper-pencil test, while the Sensory Motor Apparatus Test (SMA) and the Control Velocity Test (CVT) would be machine-based tests. These atrociously named tests, Papaji had told me, were necessary and quite fair on an air force’s part to help select only the best pilots and prevent ‘a chimp with a machine-gun’ situation.

We were directed by a non-commissioned officer (NCO) (corporals and sergeants) from the veranda to a hall in a different building. Candidates were sent inside two rooms adjoining the hall. As we walked towards the room, I could hear the muffled hum of instruments, a vibration from one corner of the hall. Quietness prevailed, and we all took our respective seats. For a moment, the whole set-up felt like a secret laboratory where we were to play the part of hamsters. An officer instructor, of the rank of wing commander, briefed us on the written test.